ConnectClips Operator's Manual

A step-by-step guide for the volunteer who turns Sunday's sermon into a week of short-form videos for YouTube Shorts, Facebook Reels, Instagram Reels, and TikTok.

What this tool does

You drop a sermon recording in. ConnectClips:

1. Transcribes the audio.
2. Asks Claude to pick the most clip-worthy moments (8 by default — you pick the best 5).
3. Reframes each pick from horizontal (16:9) to vertical (9:16) with face tracking.
4. Burns in word-by-word karaoke-style captions in the style you choose.
5. Hands you a 1080×1920 MP4 ready to upload to short-form platforms.

You then trim, export, download, and schedule each clip on each platform.

Before your first session

You need:

- **A Tailscale account** on whatever email you'd like to use (Gmail sign-in is fastest). Free; no card.
- **A device share** sent to you by the AV lead — this gives your Tailscale account access to the streaming PC. Accept the share invite from your email.
- **Tailscale installed** on the laptop, phone, or computer you'll use. Sign in with the same account you accepted the share with.
- **The URL** to access ConnectClips, which the AV lead will give you. It looks like `https://streaming-pc.taild4af82.ts.net/` (or similar — the specific tailnet name varies). You always reach the app at this same URL; no need to remember a port number or local IP.
- **A YouTube account login** for Connect Community Church's channel, plus FB / IG / TikTok if you'll be cross-posting.

You **do not need a separate password** for ConnectClips itself. The app recognizes you by your Tailscale identity — your name appears in the top-right of the page when you're connected ("Hi, *Your Name*"). Day-to-day volunteers don't need an "admin password" — that's only for the AV lead, and they set it up via Tailscale identity automatically.

The weekly rhythm

```
Sunday morning   — Service livestream.
Sunday afternoon — AV lead edits and uploads the sermon-only video to YouTube
                   (separate from the full livestream).
Sun pm / Mon am  — YOU do everything below. ~1.5 hours total.
Mon–Fri          — Scheduled posts go live automatically. Nothing for you to do.
```

You start as soon as the AV lead has uploaded the sermon-only — typically Sunday afternoon or evening. Whether you do the work Sunday night or Monday morning is up to you, **but the first clip needs to be scheduled before noon Monday so it can post that day**.

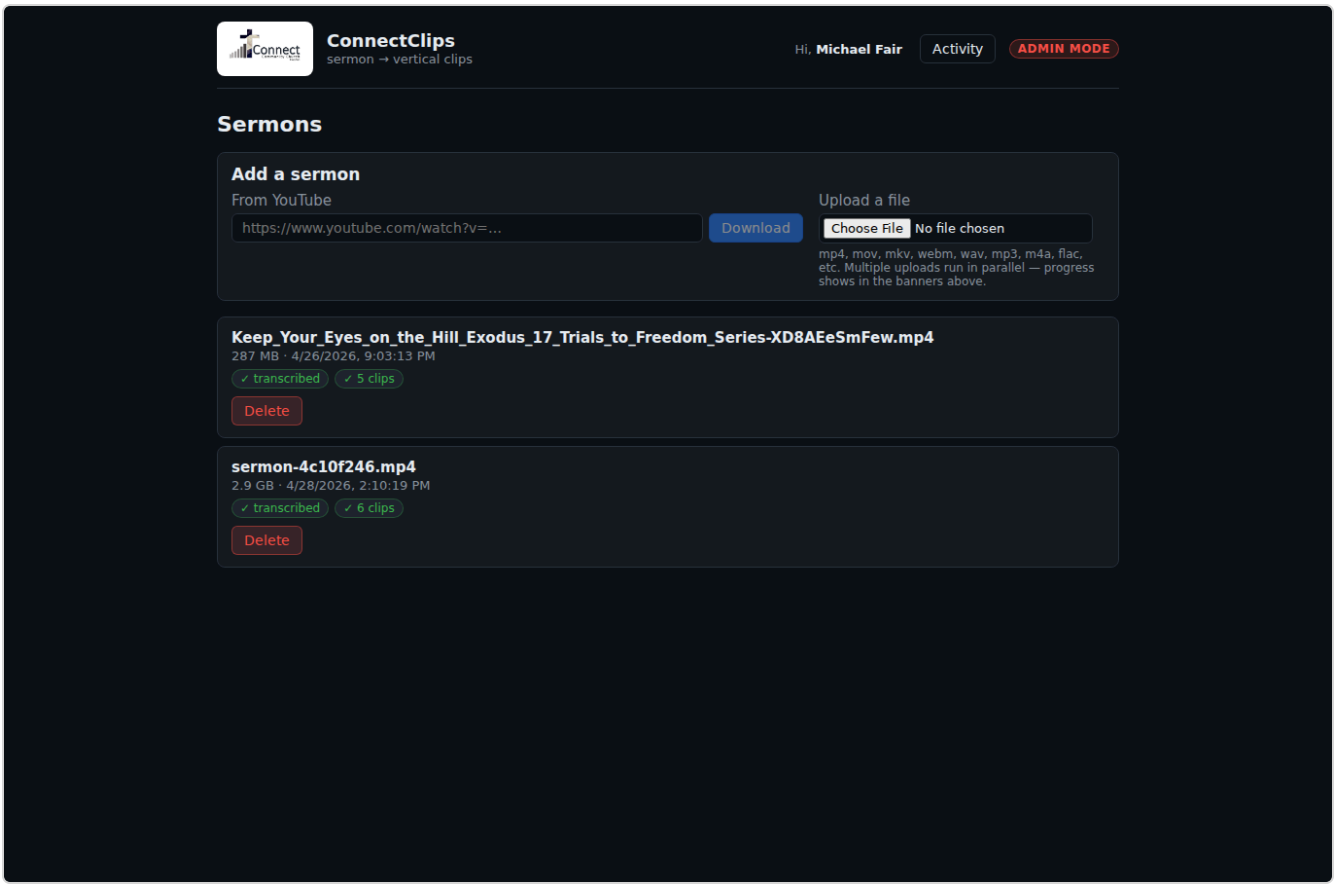
If life gets in the way and you don't get to it until Monday afternoon, that's fine — shift the schedule to **Tuesday through Saturday** instead. Both cadences work; just pick one and be consistent week to week.

The whole flow ends with five clips queued across three places (YouTube Studio, Meta Business Suite, TikTok), set to drop one per day for five days running.

The full workflow, start to finish

Step 1 — Open ConnectClips

Open the URL in any browser (Chrome, Edge, Safari). You should see a green padlock and a header showing your name in the top-right.



You'll see a list of sermons. Each one has two status badges:

- **Transcribed** — green ✓ once the words have been extracted.
- **N clips** — green ✓ once Claude has picked clip candidates.

Sermons may also show **who last touched a clip**, e.g. "exported by Sarah · 2h ago" — useful when multiple volunteers are working on different clips from the same sermon.

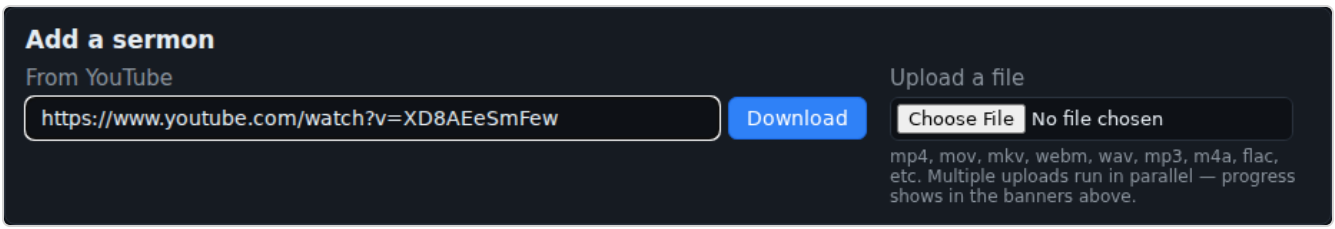
If the sermon you want is already in the list with both badges green, skip ahead to **Step 4**.

Step 2 — Add this week's sermon

In the **Add a sermon** panel at the top:

Option A — From YouTube (recommended)

Paste the URL of this week's **sermon-only** YouTube upload (not the full livestream).



Click **Download**. The button shows "Downloading…" while it pulls the video. When it finishes, the new sermon appears in the list below.

Option B — File upload

If the sermon is a local file, click **Choose File** and pick the video or audio. A **persistent progress banner** appears at the top of every page showing the upload's filename, percent, MB transferred, and a Cancel button. **The banner survives navigation** — you can browse other pages, check the Activity tab, etc., and the upload keeps going in the background.

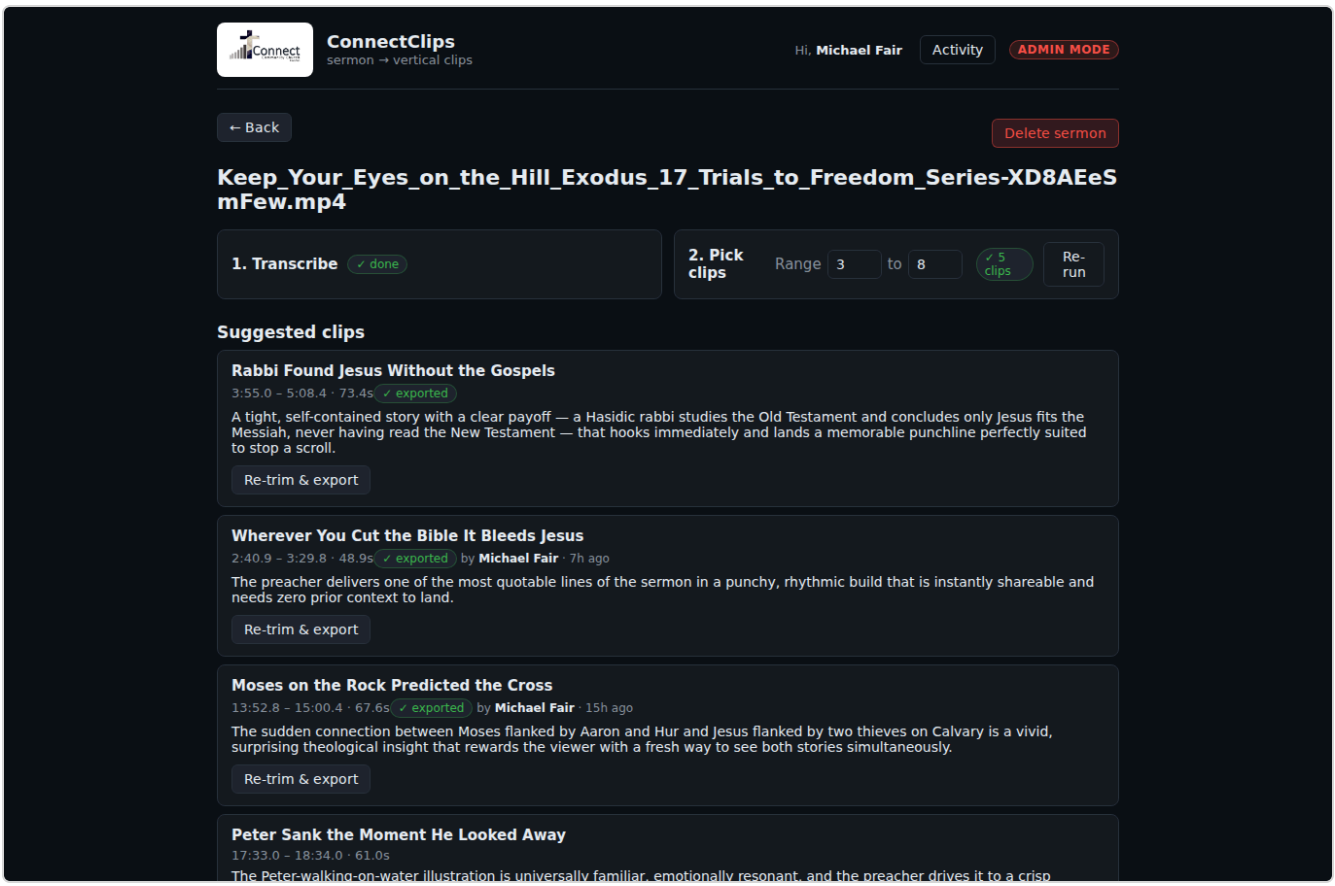
You can pick **multiple files in a row** to upload them in parallel. Each gets its own banner row. The browser handles concurrency (typically up to 6 simultaneous uploads); the rest queue automatically.

Step 3 — Wait for the auto-pipeline (a few minutes)

Once the sermon arrives (either via YouTube download or file upload), ConnectClips **automatically** runs the next two steps for you:

1. **Transcribe** — Whisper extracts every spoken word with timestamps. Takes ~5–15 minutes for a typical sermon.
2. **Pick clips** — Claude reads the transcript and returns ~8 candidate clip suggestions. ~30–60 seconds.

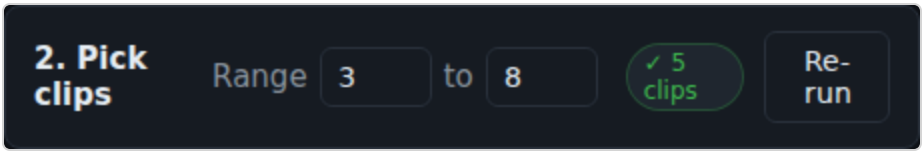
You don't need to click anything for either step — the chain runs on its own. While you wait, click the new sermon's row to open its detail page and see live progress:



Or check the **Activity** tab for a live view of every job's progress (admins only — see *Activity* below).

When both badges turn green ✓ on the sermon's row, the candidates are ready and you can move on.

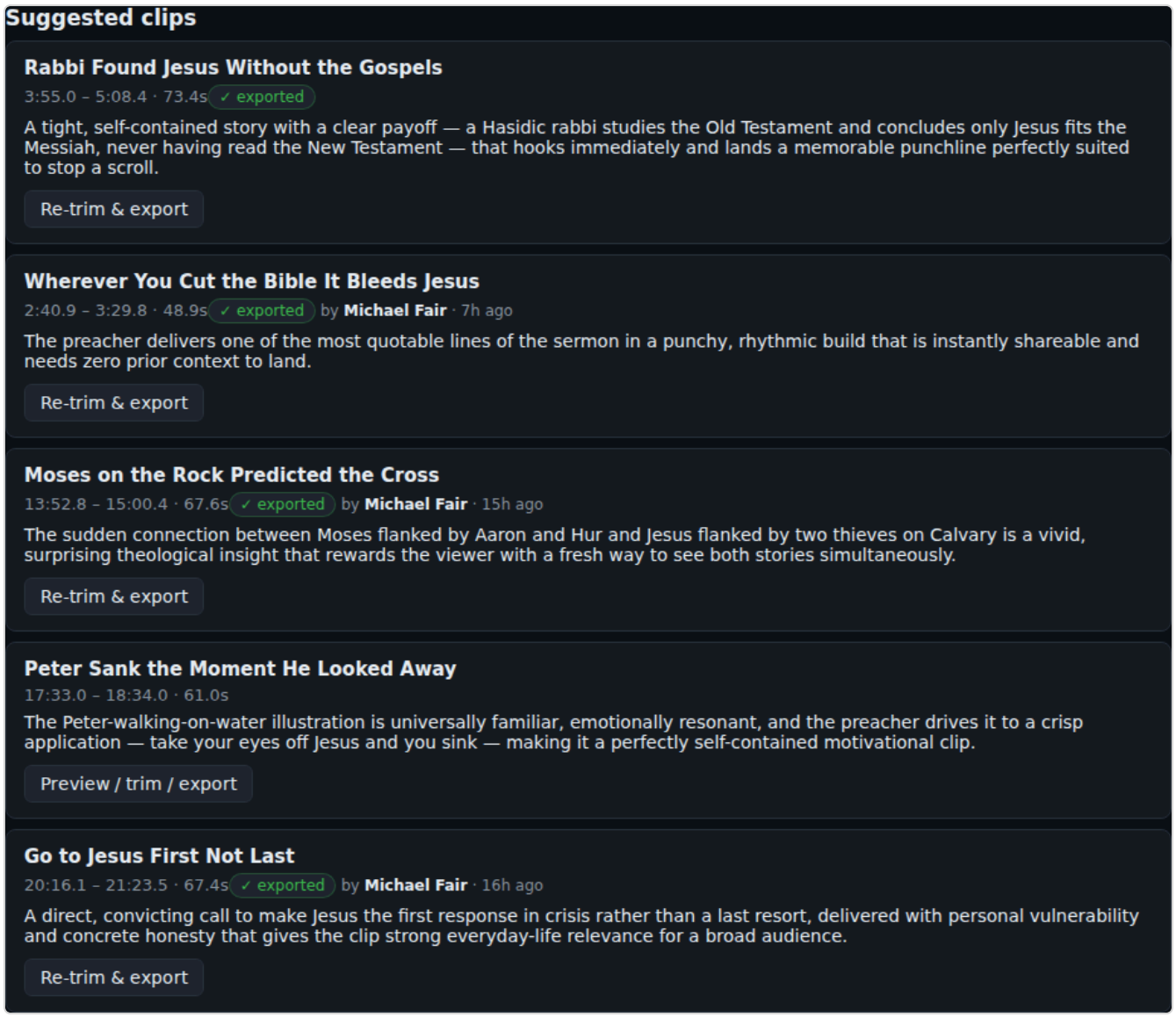
If you want a different number of clips: at the top of the sermon detail page, the **Range** controls let you change the min/max. The default is **7 to 10** (so you get ~8). Bump to **10 to 12** if you want more options to choose from, or **3 to 5** if you only want the very best moments. Click **Re-run** after changing the range.



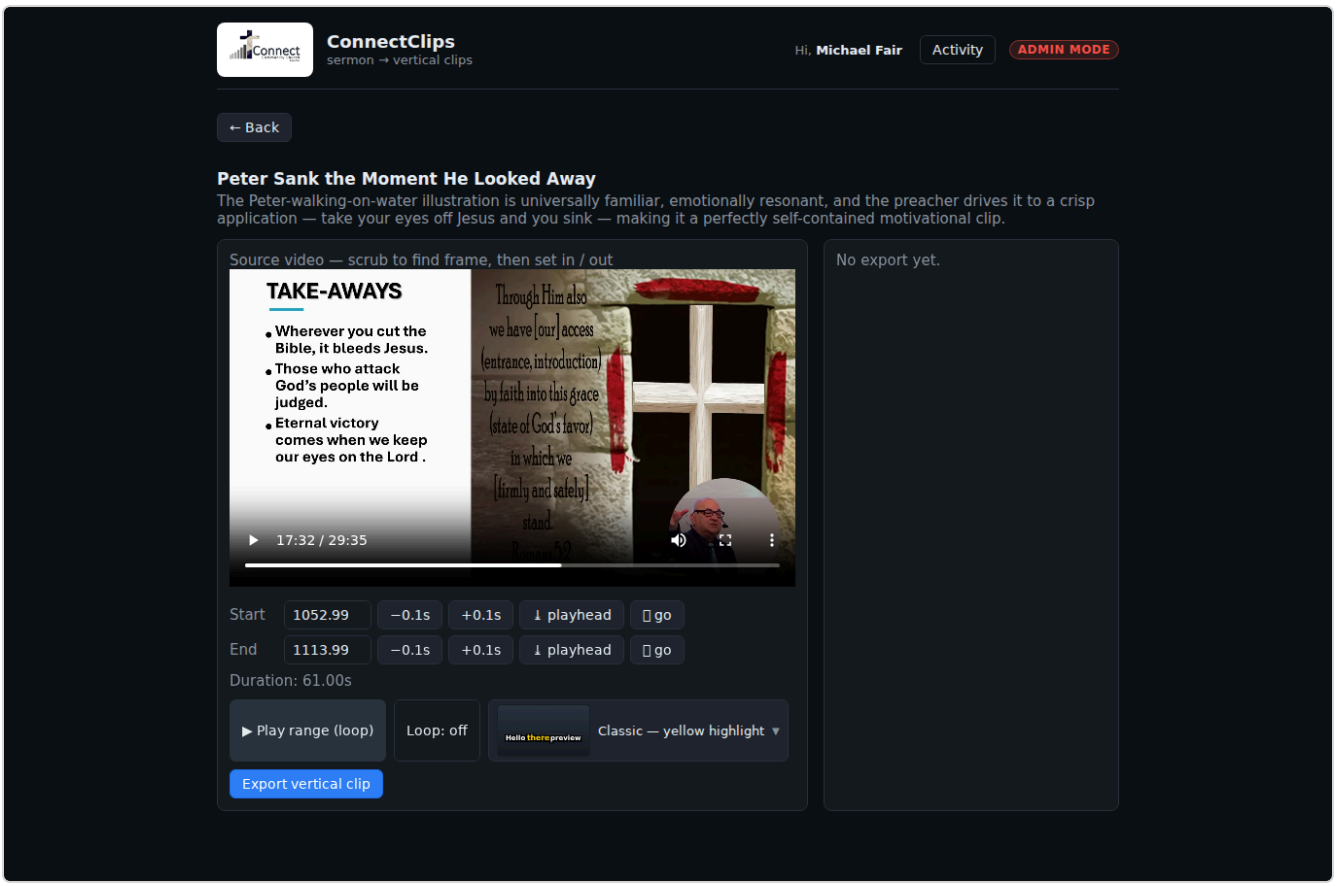
Step 4 — Review & trim each clip

Each suggested clip is a card showing:

- The clip's title (Claude wrote it; you can change it later when you upload)
- The time range and duration
- A short rationale — *why Claude thinks this moment will perform well*
- An "exported by..." note if someone has already made a vertical version of this clip



Pick a clip nobody else has worked on (or re-trim a previously exported one if it needs improvement). Click **Preview / trim / export**. You'll land in the trim view.



The left side shows the full sermon video. Scrub it like any normal video player.

The trim controls (under the video):

Control	What it does
Start / End number boxes	Type a precise time, or use the buttons to nudge
−0.1s / +0.1s	Shift start or end by a tenth of a second
⤓ playhead	Set start (or end) to wherever the video is currently parked
go	Jump the video to the current start (or end). Use this to *check* what frame you've set.
▶ Play range (loop)	Plays just the trimmed range and loops, so you can hear how the clip will feel
Loop: on / off	Toggle the loop on or off
Caption style dropdown	Pick one of five visual styles. Each option shows a live mini-preview of the karaoke effect — see below.
Export vertical clip	Kick off the reframing + caption pipeline

Caption styles — clicking the dropdown opens a small gallery. You can pick:

- **Classic** — white text with a yellow current-word highlight. Safe default.
- **Neon Pop** — pink highlight, larger pop, positioned higher in the frame.
- **Block** — text on a translucent dark bar across the bottom.
- **White Block** — black text on a near-opaque white bar with a red current-word highlight. Crisp and high-contrast.
- **Word Pop** — one big word at a time, centered. Most attention-grabbing for short, punchy clips.

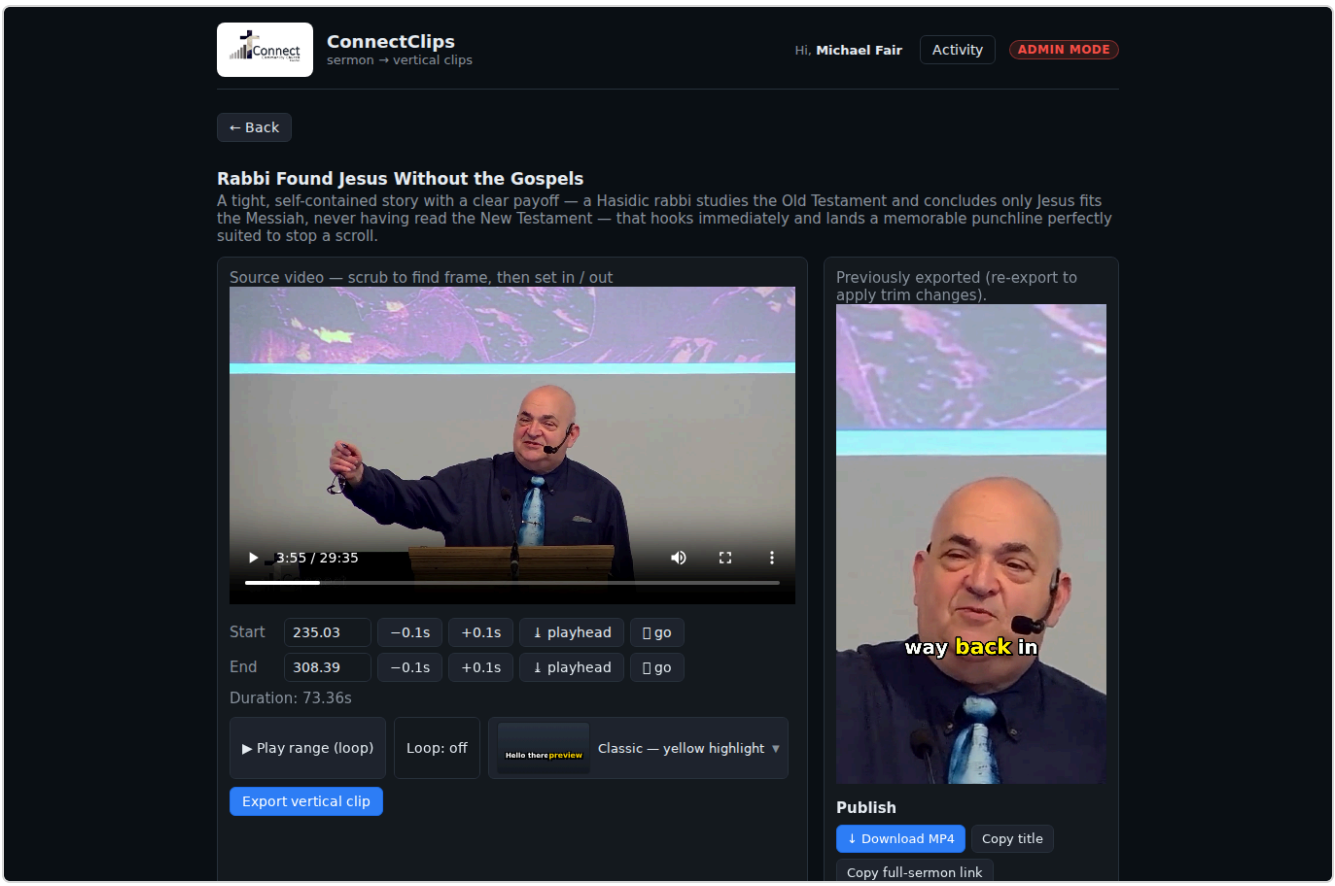
Typical trim sequence:

1. Click ▶ **Play range (loop)** to hear the clip Claude picked.
2. Listen to the very start. If it cuts in awkwardly, click pause where you want to start, then ⤓ **playhead** on the Start row.
3. Listen to the very end. If the last word is clipped, ⏭ **go** on the End row to see the last frame, then **+0.1s** until it sounds clean.
4. Re-loop with ▶ **Play range** to confirm.
5. Pick a caption style.

When happy, click **Export vertical clip**. You'll see a real progress bar (Extracting → Detecting faces → Encoding video) — the export takes about as long as the clip itself, give or take. You can navigate away if you want; the progress also appears in the Activity tab.

Step 5 — Verify the export

The exported clip appears in the right column and starts auto-playing on loop.



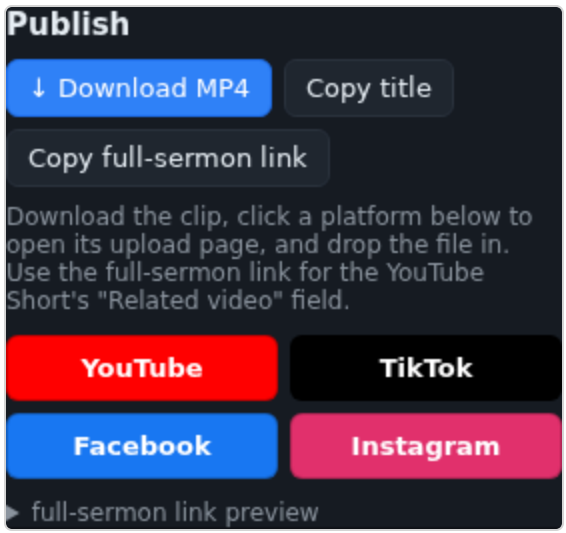
Watch it once start to finish. Check three things:

- **Pastor stays in frame.** Some moments may show the slide artwork — that's fine if it's a slide-only moment in the source. If the entire clip is slide art with no pastor, you probably need to re-trim past that section.
- **Captions appear** with the current word highlighted (color depends on the style you picked — yellow for Classic / Block, pink for Neon Pop, red for White Block).
- **The end isn't cut off mid-word.** If it is, re-trim with end +0.3s or so and re-export.

If the clip is bad, just re-trim and click **Export vertical clip** again. It'll overwrite the previous version.

Step 6 — Publish (download + cross-post)

Below the preview is the **Publish** panel.



Three action buttons across the top:

- **↓ Download MP4** — saves the clip to your Downloads folder. You'll drag this file into each platform's upload page.
- **Copy title** — puts Claude's title on your clipboard. Paste into the platform's caption field.
- **Copy full-sermon link** — only shows when the source came from YouTube. This is the URL of the original sermon at the exact timestamp the clip was taken from. **Critical for YouTube Shorts** — paste it into the "Related Video" field so viewers can click through to the full sermon.

Below those are four colored platform buttons:

Button	Opens	What you do
YouTube (red)	YouTube Studio	Upload the MP4. Set Visibility to **Schedule**. Paste the full-sermon link in the **Related Video** field.
TikTok (black)	TikTok upload page	Drop the MP4. Toggle **Schedule** and set the time.
Facebook (blue)	Facebook Reels Composer	Drop the MP4. From a Page, you can also use Meta Business Suite for cleaner scheduling.
Instagram (pink)	Instagram Reels upload	Drop the MP4. (IG strongly prefers mobile — see "Posting from your phone" below.)

Step 7 — Schedule, don't post

Don't click "Post Now" on any platform. Always **Schedule** instead. Recommended cadence: **5 clips per week, one per day at noon, for five consecutive days** — Mon-Fri if you finished the work on Sunday night, or Tue-Sat if you got to it on Monday afternoon.

Sequence by hook strength, regardless of which day you start:

Day of the run	Use the clip that...
Day 1	has the strongest scroll-stopper hook
Day 2	has the second-strongest hook
Day 3	is a teaching/insight moment
Day 4	is a story/testimony moment
Day 5	is encouraging or applicable

Read each clip's **rationale** in the sermon detail view to figure out which is which.

The strongest hook goes first because Day 1 gets the most algorithmic momentum on YouTube Shorts and TikTok — they boost newly active channels harder when the first post performs well.

Step 8 — Repeat for the remaining clips

Go back (← Back button), pick the next clip, repeat Steps 4–7. Each clip takes about 5–10 minutes once you have the rhythm.

Posting from your phone

For **Instagram Reels** specifically, the web upload is unreliable. The flow that actually works:

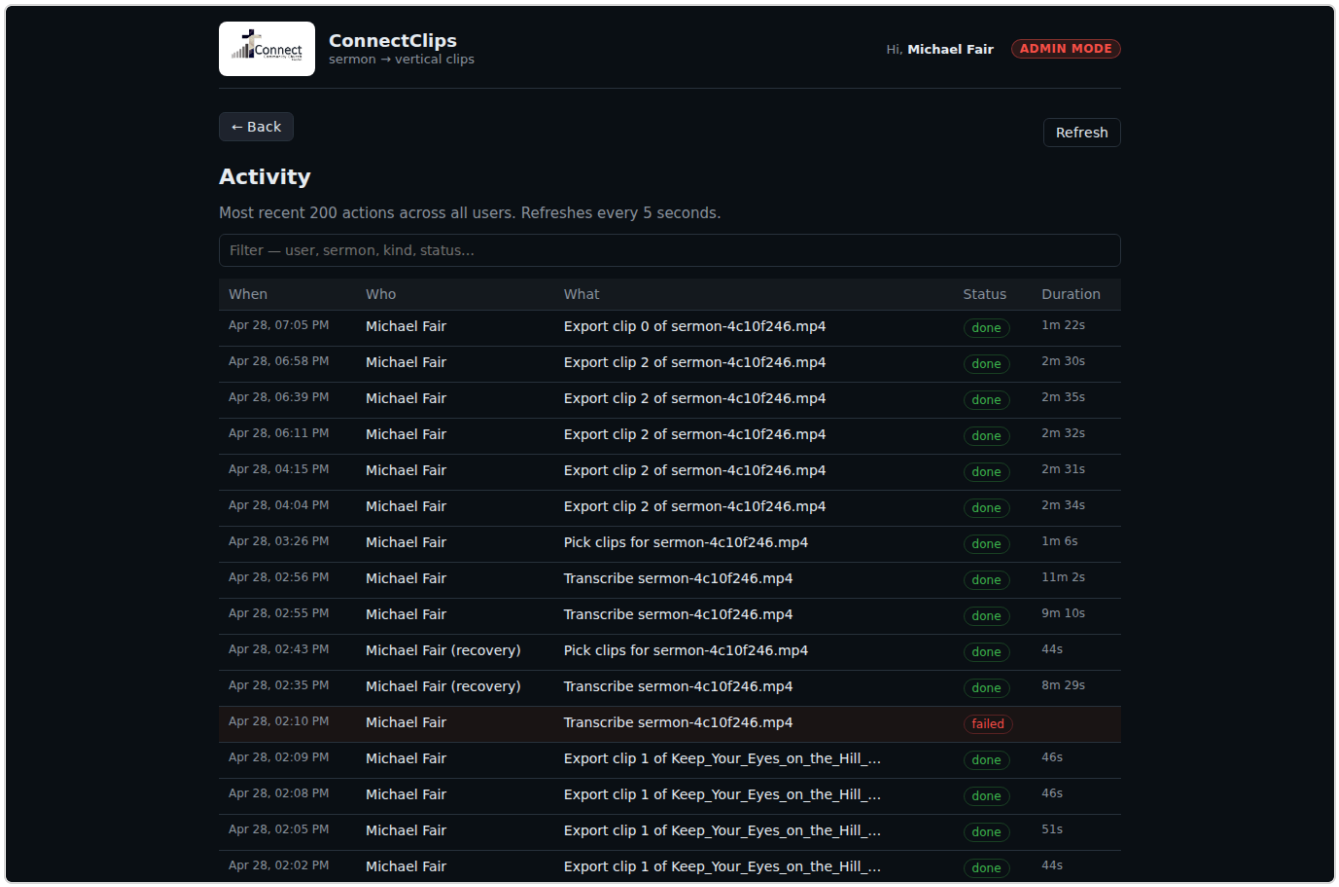
1. Email yourself the downloaded MP4 (or save to OneDrive / Google Drive).
2. Open it on your phone.
3. Open Instagram → New Post → Reel.
4. Select the MP4 from your phone's gallery.
5. Paste the title from a note you've prepped on your phone.
6. Schedule.

Same trick works for TikTok if the web flow gives you trouble.

Activity (admin only)

Click **Activity** in the top-right to see a chronological list of every job that's run — uploads, transcribes, clip selections, exports — across all volunteers. Useful when:

- A clip Claude picked seems weird and you want to confirm when it was generated.
- An export failed and you want the error message.
- You're checking who's been working on what.



The table shows: **When** the job started, **Who** triggered it, **What** kind of work, current **Status** (queued / running / done / failed), and **Duration**. Long-running jobs (transcribe and export) show a live progress bar plus the current step, e.g. "Detecting faces (320/1467)." The page auto-refreshes every 5 seconds.

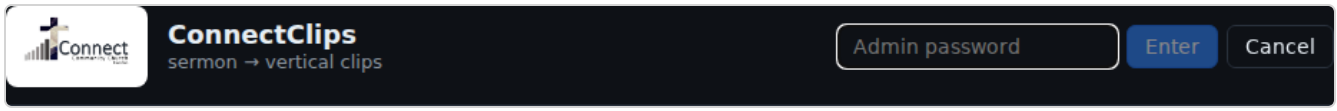
The filter box at the top live-filters across user names, sermon names, and job kinds — handy when the list gets long.

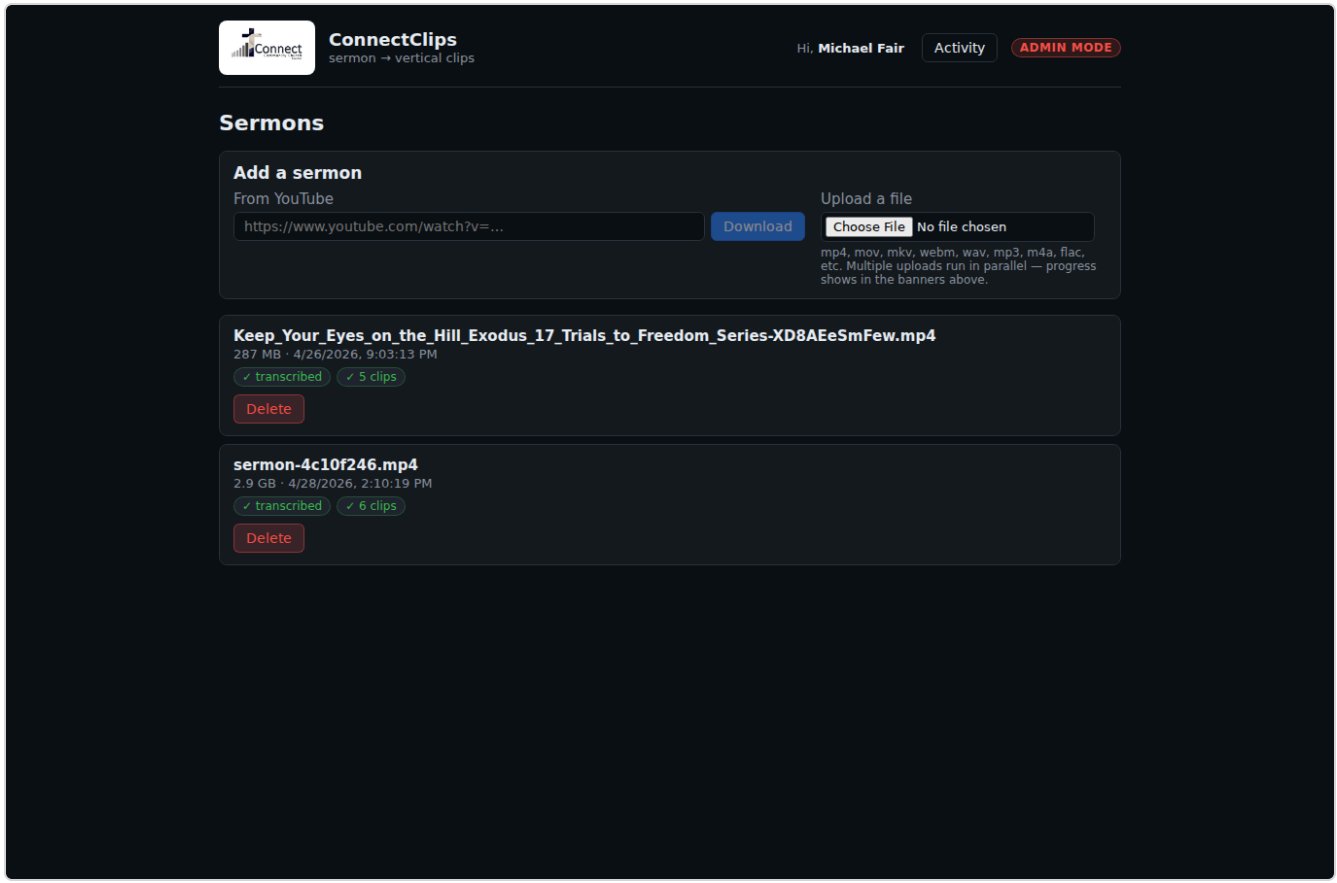
Admin mode (deleting old sermons)

This is for the AV lead, not day-to-day volunteers.

If your Tailscale email is in the admin list (configured by the AV lead in the server's `.env` file), you'll see the **`ADMIN MODE`** badge in the header automatically — no password needed. The badge stays as long as you're connected via your tailnet identity.

If you're sitting at the streaming PC directly (not via Tailscale), or your email isn't in the admin list, you can fall back to the **Enter admin mode** button in the header and type the shared admin password.





In admin mode, every sermon row gets a red **Delete** button. Clicking it asks you to confirm, then removes:

- The source video file
- The transcript
- The clips.json (Claude's picks)
- Every exported MP4 from that sermon

This is **permanent**. Don't delete a sermon you might want to re-clip later.

If you used the password to unlock admin (rather than identity), click **Exit** when you're done. Identity-based admins can't "exit" without disconnecting from Tailscale; that's by design.

Troubleshooting

The page doesn't load at all. First, confirm Tailscale is connected on your device — open the Tailscale app/menu and check that the streaming-pc is reachable. If Tailscale is fine but the URL still won't load, the backend may be down. The AV lead can check by SSH-ing into the streaming PC; the service auto-starts on boot.

The page loads but I'm "Hi, Anonymous" instead of my name. You're probably hitting the URL without going through Tailscale Serve. Use the `https://streaming-pc.<tailnet>.ts.net/` URL the AV lead gave you, not an IP address or localhost. Identity headers only flow through Tailscale Serve.

"Admin password not configured" when I try to enter admin mode. The AV lead hasn't set `ADMIN_PASSWORD` in `backend/.env`. Either ask them to add it, or — better — get added to the `ADMIN_TAILSCALE_LOGINS` list, which is the preferred admin path now.

I uploaded a file but nothing happened in the Activity tab. The upload might have failed silently. Check the upload banner at the top of the page — failures show a red row with the error and a Dismiss button. If the banner is gone (you Dismissed it earlier), try the upload again.

Transcribe is stuck on "Running…" for a long time. For a 30-minute sermon, transcribe takes about 8-12 minutes. The Activity tab now shows live percent — if the bar is moving, it's fine. If it's frozen at the same percent for >5 minutes, ask the AV lead to check the server.

Clip selection returned the same N clips after I changed the range. Check that your range *excludes* the count Claude was picking. If 8 is in the range, Claude may legitimately keep choosing 8 because that's how many strong moments exist in the sermon. Try `3 to 5` (force fewer) or `10 to 12` (force more).

The exported clip shows the slide artwork instead of the pastor. The pastor's PiP at that moment was too small for the face tracker to see. Three options: 1. Re-trim to start past the slide-heavy section (most common fix). 2. Accept it — slide artwork can look interesting and isn't a deal-breaker. 3. Pick a different clip from the suggestions list.

The last word is cut off. Re-trim with end pushed +0.3s and re-export. (New clip selections automatically add a small breath-pad to avoid this; if you re-ran clip selection on an old sermon, the fix takes effect for new picks.)

Captions look duplicated / stacked / out of sync. Refresh the page (F5 — no need for the hard-refresh / Ctrl+Shift+R any more). If it's still wrong on the *exported file* (not the in-app preview), re-export the clip — the file gets overwritten cleanly.

Captions are in the wrong color. You picked a different style on a previous export and it's remembered for this session. Open the caption-style dropdown and choose the one you actually want, then export again.

Quick reference card

What you want to do	Where in the app
Add a sermon from YouTube	Sermon list → top panel → paste URL → Download
Upload a local file	Sermon list → top panel → Choose File
Upload multiple files at once	Pick them one at a time — each runs in parallel; banners stack
Cancel an upload	Click the Cancel button on its banner row
See what's already in progress	Sermon list — status badges on each row, OR Activity tab
Re-pick clips with a different count	Sermon detail → Step 2 → set Range → Re-run
Trim and export a clip	Click "Preview / trim / export" on a clip card
Change caption style	Trim view → caption-style dropdown next to Export button
Download a finished clip	Trim view → Publish panel → ↓ Download MP4
Get the YouTube deep-link	Trim view → Publish panel → Copy full-sermon link
Open a platform's upload page	Trim view → Publish panel → colored platform button
See activity history	Header → Activity (admin only)
Delete an old sermon	Header → admin badge or Enter admin mode → Delete on the row

A note on what this tool can't do

ConnectClips picks moments and reframes them, but it doesn't (yet):

- Generate thumbnails (use the platform's auto-pick, or design one in Canva)
- Write platform-specific captions (Claude's title is a starting point; you'll polish it per platform)
- Detect what makes a clip "viral" (Claude is good at this but not infallible — your editorial judgment in the trim view is the safety net)
- Cross-post in one click (you'll schedule on each platform individually — see Step 7)

The trim view is your editorial gate. If a clip Claude picked feels off, skip it. Quality over quantity always wins on short-form.